

María de los Ángeles Lasa, PhD

Applied Data Science · Computational Social Science

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Profile

Political scientist and data scientist with 10+ years of experience in mixed-methods research and applied analytics. I design and implement data and AI tools that enable CSOs, international organizations, and governments to measure, evaluate, and communicate the impact of their programs. I translate complex analysis for non-technical audiences and support evidence-based decision-making. Published author, international speaker, and university lecturer.

Professional experience

Applied Data Science Manager · Global Fund for Women

Dec 2022 – Present

Gender Justice Data Hub · Remote for San Francisco, United States

- Designed and built GAIA, a conversational assistant with a RAG architecture for exploring the narrative reports of grantee partners. I implemented the full pipeline, including cleaning and preparing the corpus, the chunking strategy, the multilingual embeddings, the vector database, and the generation layer. I also developed a systematic evaluation strategy covering answer faithfulness and retrieval relevance.
- Led the consolidation of the institutional tagging taxonomy, reducing it from 111 to roughly 55 categories on the basis of phi coefficients, usage rates, and residuality rules, while reconciling proposals from different teams.
- Built from scratch the analytical stack of the Gender Justice Data Hub and designed in-house instruments for detecting and monitoring gender justice movements. These include the *Social Movements Index*, which measures the intensity and persistence of social mobilization across 195 countries using ACLED data; the *Peak Detection Algorithm*, which identifies unusual spikes in protest activity; and the *Agendas Mapper*, which detects emerging thematic patterns through unsupervised learning. Together, these tools enable the identification and monitoring of early signals of mobilization associated with gender justice movements.

Director of Legacy and Sustainability · XIX Pan American Games Santiago 2023

May – Dec 2022

Executive Directorate · Santiago, Chile

- Defined the mega-event's legacy and sustainability strategy, together with its measurement framework, in coordination with technical areas and public counterparts.

Research and Data Analysis Manager · Movilizadorio

Apr 2020 – Apr 2022

Projects Directorate · Remote for Bogotá, Colombia

- Led the research and data strategy for projects on disinformation, media literacy, judicial protection of migrants, polarisation, political participation, and anti-vaccine movements, for philanthropic organizations, international agencies, and clients, including Google News Initiative, USAID, Climate and Land Use Alliance, Chemonics, and GlaxoSmithKline.
- Provided technical leadership for a pioneering study on polarisation in Colombia, based on K-means segmentation and the incorporation of Moral Foundations Theory. The study was conducted in partnership with More in Common UK and funded by the Ford Foundation, the Open Society Foundations, and the Embassy of Canada in Colombia. It was covered by 25+ media outlets, including Infobae, Semana, El Espectador, Caracol Radio, and RCN Radio.

Data Analyst · Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development

Jul – Sep 2019

Open Government Unit · Paris, France

- Analyzed comparative open government data to inform public policy advice for member and partner countries.

Project Consultant · Oxford Development Consultancy

Oct 2018 – Mar 2019

Oxford, United Kingdom

Legacy and Sustainability Manager · Youth Olympic Games BA2018

Apr 2017 – Sep 2018

Corporate Planning Department · Buenos Aires, Argentina

AML/CFT Compliance Officer · Financial Intelligence Unit

Oct 2016 – Mar 2017

International Affairs Department · Buenos Aires, Argentina

Education

Master of Public Policy

2018 – 2019

University of Oxford, St Antony's College, United Kingdom. Upper Second-Class Honors (64). Final report: Merit.

PhD in Political Science

2011 – 2014

Università degli Studi di Camerino, Italy. Insigni Cum Laude. Thesis: Ottimo (5/5).

BA in International Relations

2005 – 2009

Universidad Católica de Córdoba, Argentina. Distinction. GPA: 9.05/10.

Additional training

10+ postgraduate programs and summer schools in Argentina, Chile, Spain, the United States, and Israel. Selected programs relevant to computational methods and public policy analysis:

Postgraduate Diploma in Artificial Intelligence School of Engineering, Universidad Austral, Argentina	Mar – Sep 2026
Summer School in Mixed Methods Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile	Jan 2025
Postgraduate Diploma in Computational Social Science Universidad Nacional de San Martín, Argentina	Apr – Dec 2024
Postgraduate Program in Big Data and Territorial Intelligence FLACSO Argentina	Apr – Dec 2023
Oxford-Blavatnik Policy Program Tel Aviv University, Israel	Mar 2019
Postgraduate Program in Public Policy Design and Evaluation Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Argentina campus	Mar – Dec 2017

Technical skills

Programming languages: Python, R, SQL, LaTeX, HTML.

AI and NLP: LLMs and prompting, RAG systems, multilingual embeddings, vector databases, multi-label text classification, topic modeling.

Machine learning: supervised and unsupervised learning, regression and classification models, clustering (K-means), anomaly detection, feature engineering, and computer vision.

Data and visualization: BigQuery, Power BI, Tableau, Flourish, Gephi, SPSS, and advanced Excel.

Methods: mixed-methods research design, inferential statistics, impact evaluation, sampling, network analysis, spatial analysis, and time series.

Teaching and research

Universidad Nacional de La Plata , Argentina Lecturer on the MA in International Relations and associate researcher at the Center for Korean Studies.	2025 – Present
Instituto Tecnológico de Monterrey , Mexico Training partner for <i>Data Science for Decision-Making II</i> , Program in Government and Public Transformation.	2024 – Present
Universidad de San Andrés , Argentina Teaching assistant and co-supervisor of undergraduate theses in quantitative methods and computational text analysis.	Aug – Dec 2025
Universidad Comunera , Paraguay Lecturer in Political Science for Public Policy, Postgraduate Diploma in Public Policy. Student evaluation: 4.90/5.	2020 – 2025
Universidad Torcuato Di Tella , Argentina Visiting lecturer in State and Public Policy in Argentina. Student evaluation: 4.55/5.	2021 – 2022

Additional information

Publications: author of *País de vinalón: mi viaje a Corea del Norte* (CADAL, 2024; Eduvim, 2025), as well as articles in peer-reviewed journals, book chapters, and press pieces in outlets from Argentina, South Korea, and the United Kingdom.

International speaker: speaker at TEDxRecoleta, TEDxUCC, WiDS 2023, csv.conf.v8, and Nerdearla. Presenter at more than 30 conferences and forums in Argentina, Belgium, Chile, Colombia, Italy, Mexico, Peru, Sweden, Switzerland, and the United States.

Awards: *Ten Outstanding Young Persons of Argentina*, JCI (2023). Honorable Mention, XXXVI Luis José de Tejada Literature Prize (2023). Research Excellence Prize, Università degli Studi di Camerino (2013). *St. Gallen Wings of Excellence Award*, 3rd prize (2011). World Bank *Ideas4Action* Competition, 1st prize (2010). *World Bank International Essay Competition*, 2nd prize (2010).

Scholarships: Fundación Carolina (€4,000), Fulbright (USD 8,000), Consorzio Universitario Italiano per l'Argentina (€48,476), Chevening (£47,569), Blavatnik School of Government (£7,376), Erasmus+ (€800).

Affiliations: Academic advisor to the Center for the Opening and Development of Latin America (CADAL). Chevening Alumni Argentina. Graduate member of the Argentine Society of Political Analysis (SAAP). Oxford Union Society. R-Ladies Global. Red de Politólogos.

Languages: Spanish (native). English (advanced, IELTS 7.5). Italian (intermediate, B2).